

Potential energy

Any type of energy that is stored and ready to do something is called potential energy. Potential energy is found inside everything from chemicals and elastic to electricity and everyday objects.

If you ride a bike to the top of a hill, its potential energy increases. The bike is then ready to roll down the other side.

Elastic potential energy

This energy is stored in a material when you stretch or squash it. Once stretched, the material is ready to spring back.

Elastic potential energy is also called spring energy, for this reason!

The bow string is stretched and ready to spring back to fire the arrow.

How springs work

A spring can be made from any firm and flexible material, wound around in circles. The material and shape let the spring store elastic potential energy. Some mattresses contain springs, which make you bounce if you jump on the bed!



A metal spring